Poem: The Echoing Green (William Blake)

Stanza-by-stanza explanation — meaning, devices, theme, and likely board questions

About the Poem

Poet: William Blake (1757–1827), English poet and painter. **Form:** 3 stanzas, simple song-like rhymes. **Theme:** The joyful harmony of nature and human life; innocence; the cycle of life (morning = youth, evening = age).

Stanza 1

The sun does arise,
And make happy the skies.
The merry bells ring
To welcome the Spring.
The sky-lark and thrush,
The birds of the bush,
Sing louder around
To the bells' cheerful sound.
While our sports shall be seen
On the Echoing Green.

• **Meaning:** The sun rises and makes the skies happy. Merry bells ring to welcome spring. The sky-lark, thrush, and birds of the bush sing louder around to the bells' cheerful sound. The children's sports (games) are seen on the Echoing Green.

• **Devices:** Personification — the sun "makes happy the skies" and the bells ring "to welcome the Spring" (given human feelings). Alliteration — "sky-lark," "Sing louder." Auditory imagery — bells and birdsong. Rhyme — arise/skies, ring/Spring.

• **Theme:** Innocence and joy. Morning symbolises youth. Nature and children celebrate together.

• **Board angle:** The present tense ("does arise," "ring," "sing") gives the poem a timeless quality — this scene happens every day.

Stanza 2

Old John, with white hair
Does laugh away care,
Sitting under the oak,
Among the old folk,
They laugh at our play,
And soon they all say:
"Such, such were the joys
When we all, girls & boys,
In our youth-time were seen
On the Echoing Green."

• **Meaning:** Old John, with white hair, laughs away care, sitting under the oak among the old folk. They laugh at the children's play and say: "Such were the joys when we all, girls and boys, in our youth-time were seen on the Echoing Green."

• **Devices:** The repetition of "Such, such" emphasises the elders' memory. Direct speech (the old folk's words) connects past and present. The oak symbolises age and shelter.

• **Theme:** Continuity between generations. The elders remember their own youth on the same green. The "echoing" of the green symbolises memory — the past echoes in the present.

• **Board angle:** The old folk's role is the key to the poem's meaning: they link the children's present joy with their own past joy.

Stanza 3

Till the little ones wear
No more can be merry;
The sun does descend,
And our sports have an end.
Round the cedar's shade
Our mothers, sisters and brothers
Are ready for rest;
And no more we're seen
On the darkening Green.

• **Meaning:** The little ones can be merry no more. The sun descends and the sports end. Round the cedar's shade, mothers, sisters, and brothers are ready for rest. The children are no more seen on the darkening Green.

• **Devices:** The contrast between stanza 1 and stanza 3: "arise" vs. "descend," "happy skies" vs. "darkening Green," "merry bells" vs. "no more can be merry." The cedar's shade replaces the oak — evening replaces morning.

• **Theme:** The passage of time and the cycle of life. Just as day moves from morning to evening, life moves from youth to age and rest. The ending is peaceful, not sad — rest is a natural part of the cycle.

• **Board angle:** The shift from lively activity to quietness symbolises the cycle of life. The poem begins with sunrise and ends with sunset.

Overall Message

• The poem celebrates the joyful harmony of nature and human life. The green is the meeting place of all generations.

• The progression of the day reflects the cycle of life: bright morning (youth) gives way to calm evening (age and rest).

• The "echoing green" symbolises memory and continuity — the joys of one generation echo in the next.

Likely Board Questions (Reference to Context)

Q1. Explain with reference to the context: "The sun does arise, / And make happy the skies."

These lines from "The Echoing Green" by William Blake signify the beginning of a new day, symbolising renewal, hope, and the start of a fresh cycle. The rising sun lights the sky, creating a positive and uplifting atmosphere. The personification of the sun making the skies happy enhances the tone of innocence and joy, where nature is portrayed as lively and vibrant.

Q2. Explain with reference to the context: "Such, such were the joys / When we all, girls & boys, / In our youth-time were seen / On the Echoing Green."

These lines are spoken by the old folk in the poem. They remember their own childhood joys on the same green. The repetition of "Such, such" emphasises their memory. The lines show continuity between generations — the past echoes in the present, which is why the green is called "echoing."

Q3. Explain with reference to the context: "The sun does descend, / And our sports have an end."

These lines mark the end of the day and of childhood joy. Just as the sun descends, the children's sports end and everyone rests. The lines symbolise the passage of time and the cycle of life — youth gives way to age, just as morning gives way to evening. The mood is calm and peaceful.

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